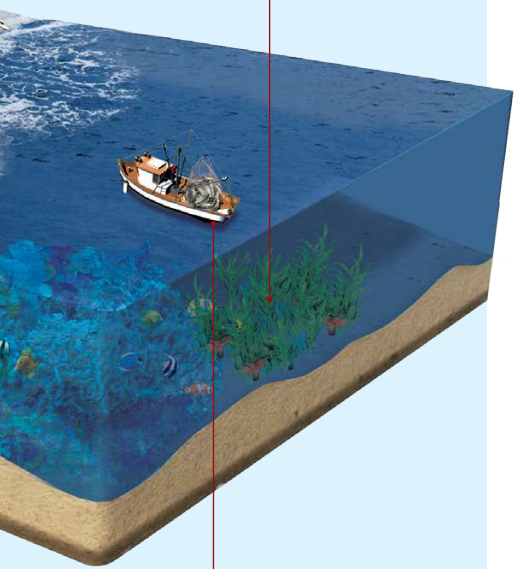
Despite the sea's assimilation abilities, chemical-infested effluents are known to reduce the oxygen content in water, creating dead zones

The dangerous chemicals may also come back into human circulation via seaweeds, used extensively in pharmaceutical, cosmetics and wellness products



Chemical remnants in fish, say studies, are deemed cancerous for human consumption



"IF THE COST OF TREATING CERTAIN CHEMICALS IS TOO HIGH, THEN THE SOLUTION IS TO PHASE THEM OUT, NOT DUMP THEM INTO THE SEA"

ROHIT PRAJAPATI,
Environmental Activist

not face serious concern yet," maintains NCCR director Dr M.V. Ramana Murthy. "If the norms are followed, we should be able to maintain the ecological balance."

Eventually, it all boils down to the effective working of common effluent treatment plants (CETPs), set up to help small- and medium-scale enterprises—which are unable to afford the installation of pollution-control equipment—dispose of the effluents safely and economically. But in the case of deep-sea discharge, monitoring becomes all the more difficult as it may take time for the impact of dilution to become apparent.

"Dilution is not the solution," says environmental activist Rohit Prajapati. A member of the joint task force formed by the Gujarat High Court to deal with pollution in the Sabarmati, Prajapati suggests that if the cost of treating certain chemicals is financially unsustainable for businesses, then "the solution is to phase out such chemicals, not dump them untreated into the sea".

Poor functioning and monitoring of CETPs and flouting of effluent treatment norms by industries are the precise reasons that the rivers in Gujarat are severely polluted. A 27-km-long pipeline, which discharged treated effluents from three industrial clusters around Ahmedabad into the Sabarmati, had to be shut down earlier this year, says a reliable source privy to the development, after the detection of 167 illegal connections. How a 210-km pipeline passing through multiple industrial estates and villages will be monitored is anyone's guess.

According to a veteran scientist, who prefers to remain anonymous, regulators decide the effluent discharge norms based on the existing pollution load of a water body, be it a river or a sea. "We do not have a detailed study regarding the carrying capacity of the Arabian Sea, particularly the Gulf of Khambhat," he notes. "Then on what basis have the discharge norms been decided?" In its written reply in the state assembly on September 15, in fact, the Gujarat government had admitted that the environmental impact assessment is not needed to lay a deep-sea discharge pipeline.

KEY LESSONS

Prajapati says that a 2021 high court order had noted that the tidal activity in the Gulf of Khambhat "drives the highly toxic and polluted wastewater inland, to the estuaries of the Mahisagar and Sabarmati rivers, causing tremendous risk to the settlements, villages and towns in the region". The functioning of the existing marine outfall does not inspire any confidence either. A report by the Narmada Pradushan Nivaran Samiti, a non-governmental organisation, in 2020—four years after the Jhagadia pipeline was made operational—alleged that the effluents did not meet the norms at the point of discharge from the CETP. Even as a committee appointed by the National Green Tribunal concluded that, barring a few exceptions, the treated effluents were within permissible limits, it conceded another finding of the NGO—there were over two dozen leakages in the pipeline, due to which the hazardous waste was seeping into farmlands.

According to a senior GPCB official, who talked to INDIA TODAY on the condition of anonymity, the working of the new CETPs will be monitored every fortnight, though checking the entire pipeline will still not be possible. "Agencies like the National Institute of Oceanography and the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research typically measure the impact [of outfalls] on marine life and ecology every two to three years," he adds. "The Jhagadia pipeline hasn't been found to damage the marine ecology." Given that such claims have been contested time and again, it is imperative that the Gujarat government addresses all concerns promptly if it wants the project to be a success, from both environmental and economic perspectives. ■